ROUTLEDGE MARKETING ANALYTICS | FY2026 BUDGET REVIEW | OCTOBER 2025

Marketing performance and the FY2026 budget

Which numbers to trust, which channels earn their money, and where next year's paid media should go

Routledge sells its books direct to students, instructors, researchers and professionals through routledge.com, in the US, the UK and the rest of the world. This report covers 1 October 2022 to 30 September 2025 and was written in October 2025, while the FY2026 marketing budget was being set.

The business context is real; the data is simulated. No figure in this report describes actual Taylor & Francis performance.

Summary

Ahead of the FY2026 budget, leadership asked for a measure of marketing performance they could trust, an honest view of which channels and partners earn their money, and a budget built on gross profit rather than on what the ad platforms report. This report answers the five questions behind that request. Every figure comes from SQL run in BigQuery, the two analysis notebooks, the dashboard, the budget planner or the CRM lifecycle plan.

Measure	1 October 2022 to 30 September 2025
Orders	75,918
Customers (people, after merging duplicate accounts)	58,101
Net revenue, after discounts and refunds	$11,907,875
Gross profit	$7,421,060, 62.3 percent of net revenue
Marketing cost	$1,474,625: ad spend $1,247,289 plus affiliate commission $227,336
Net revenue per dollar of marketing cost (MER)	8.08
Average order value, after refunds	$156.85
New customers who order again within 12 months (customers acquired by 30 September 2024)	19.6 percent

What to do

	Recommendation	What it is worth	Confidence
1	Pay coupon partners only on orders credited to them (Pay on credit), and hold all commission for 45 days, dropping it if the order is refunded within the 45 days (Refund hold)	$44,202 a year; $132,607 over the last three years	High on the amount; some coupon partners may leave
2	Move a fifth of Meta Retargeting's budget, $10,945, to Google Non Brand, holding paid media at FY2025's $498,948	Against repeating FY2025's budgets, -$6,844 of gross profit after ad spend under last click and +$24,388 under position based. The planner's totals, +$37,359 and +$68,590, include item 1	Medium; last click alone would keep retargeting
3	No extra budget for Meta Prospecting until its checkout drop off is explained	Lifting its checkout to purchase rate from about 13 to 20 percent would give about 1.5 times the orders	High that no increase is warranted
4	Pause UK brand search for 8 weeks as the first holdout test	Saves $1,209; brand search must protect 10.8 percent of the $11,182 of gross profit it is credited with in those weeks	Simple design; the answer is unknown until it runs
5	Point CRM at the second order, timed to the term, with a 20 percent holdout on every programme	Each point of twelve month repeat is about 110 more repeat customers a year, about $13,500 of gross profit	Medium, measured by the holdout

What the analysis found

- **The platforms over-claim, and every step can be sized.** Over the 51 complete weeks of FY2025 Google and Meta claimed 21,101 orders and 15,280 happened. Meta's view through purchases are part of the gap; the rest fits inside what the click windows allow. Budgets use internal ROAS (4.83 in those weeks), not the 5.83 the platforms report.
- **Last click flatters the channels that close.** Under position based attribution in FY2025, Google Brand's ROAS falls from 14.80 to 8.66 and Meta Retargeting's from 6.14 to 3.15, while Meta Prospecting's rises from 2.68 to 4.14. 84.0 percent of the orders brand search closes began on another channel.
- **Every channel with a cost pays back on the first order,** so the budget question is incrementality. No channel has a holdout, so it is tested as an assumption against each channel's break even share: 11.0 percent for Google Brand, 57.1 for Meta Prospecting.
- **Customers come back for a later term, not the next month.** 77.6 percent have bought once; 0.63 percent buy again in the month after a first order, and the share peaks at 2.35 percent in month 8.
- **Coupon partners are mostly paid on orders other channels won**, 71.1 percent of coupon commission. On those GA4 saw, the buying session had started before the coupon click on 94.8 percent, against 10.8 percent on orders credited to coupon partners.
- **Meta Prospecting is the largest budget and, under last click, the weakest return.** Its visitors reach checkout and do not buy, and 4.5 percent of its customers order again within a year.

What is not known

- How incremental any channel is, and whether any sale creates demand or only moves it.
- Why Meta Prospecting visitors abandon checkout, and why conversion ran high for five weeks in May and June 2025.
- Why customers who first bought on a sale day without the code are worth more than the other two first order groups.

The business and the data

The question

It is October 2025 and the FY2026 marketing budget is being prepared. Routledge runs paid search on Google, paid social on Meta, email, coupon and content affiliate partners, and four sales a year (back to college, Black Friday, New Year and mid-year). Leadership does not trust the ad platforms' numbers, suspects some channels take credit for sales that would have happened anyway, and wants the budget built on profit. Five questions came out of that:

1. Can we trust our numbers, and which number should be used for which decision?
2. How is each channel performing on revenue and profit, including brand against non brand search?
3. Which channels bring valuable customers, how fast do they pay back, and how should CRM win their second order?
4. Which channels and partners create sales that would not have happened anyway?
5. How should the FY2026 budget be split?

The data and the definitions

Three years of data, 1 October 2022 to 30 September 2025, in ten raw tables: orders (76,058), order lines, customer accounts (58,432), refunds, Google Ads and Meta Ads by day, affiliate network transactions (17,369), the sales calendar, daily exchange rates, and the GA4 export (6,009,850 events, October 2024 to September 2025 only). Every figure is reported in US dollars. FY2025 runs from 1 October 2024 to 30 September 2025, the year GA4 covers. In BigQuery, `raw` holds the tables as they arrived, and no value in it is ever changed (the GA4 table is only reshaped once into the standard export structure); `clean` holds everything built from them, so every fix happens once. Tools: BigQuery SQL, Python on Google Colab (pandas, scipy, statsmodels, matplotlib), Power BI and a spreadsheet. The data dictionary describes every table and column.

Term	Definition	Value
Net revenue	Order value after discounts and refunds, excluding tax and shipping. Revenue before refunds is always labelled	$11,907,875 (before refunds $12,296,260)
Gross profit	Net revenue less product cost, shipping cost, payment fees and affiliate commission; before ad spend	$7,421,060
Customer	A person after duplicate accounts are merged; acquisition channel is the channel of the first order	58,101
Marketing cost	Ad spend plus affiliate commission. There is no email cost data	$1,474,625
Paid CAC / Blended CAC	Ad spend over paid new customers / marketing cost over all new customers	$37.07 / $25.38
Cost per new customer	Ad spend over a channel's new customers; blank where there is no ad spend. In the unit economics, affiliates use first order commission instead	
Internal ROAS	Net revenue after refunds, last click, over ad spend	4.70 paid
Platform ROAS	Revenue the platform claims over spend, always labelled	5.66 paid
MER	Net revenue over marketing cost	8.08
Conversion rate	GA4 purchasing sessions over GA4 sessions	2.21 percent
Repeat rate	New customers ordering again within 12 months, on customers whose first order was on or before 30 September 2024	19.6 percent
12 month value	Gross profit per customer in the 12 months after the first order, same customers	$118.82
LTV to CAC	12 month value over cost per new customer, same customers	5.81 all channels
Break even incrementality	Share of a channel's credited new customers that must be genuinely new for it to cover its cost over 12 months	

Orders belong to the channel recorded at checkout (last click) unless a section says otherwise. Rates are worked out from summed parts, never averaged; the kinds of ROAS are never mixed; channel decisions are judged on gross profit. Incremental ROAS is not measured, because no channel has a holdout or experiment.

How the work is built

File	What it does
`01_load_and_checks.sql`, `02_data_audit.sql`	Check every raw table and size every data problem, feeding the data issues log
`03_clean_layer.sql`	Six clean tables: test orders removed, accounts merged into people, channels mapped, spend in dollars, GA4 sessions
`04_reporting_tables.sql`	The four dashboard tables (channel and funnel by day, campaigns by week, tracking health) and the Meta checkout and cost per click queries
`05_customer_value.sql`	`customer_value`: one row per customer with acquisition channel, sale group, 12 month value, RFM scores and lifecycle stage
`06_reconciliation_attribution.sql`	Platform claims by week, journeys under four rules, affiliate transactions
`01_customer_value.ipynb`	Retention, repeat, CAC, LTV to CAC, payback, sale groups, stages and CRM audiences; writes `unit_economics`
`02_reconciliation_attribution.ipynb`	The reconciliation walk, ROAS by source, attribution with bootstrap tests, brand search, affiliates and commission terms
Power BI report, budget planner	The four page dashboard; the FY2026 budget split

1. Can we trust our numbers?

> **THE ANSWER**
> Yes, once the data is cleaned and each number is used for the right job. The ad platforms claim more than happened, for reasons that can each be sized. Budgets use internal ROAS from the order system. GA4 is fair for comparing channels but sees only about 88 percent of orders.

What the audit found

The data issues log holds 29 findings, each sized and decided (13 closed, 14 known limitations, 2 open), and 53 checks, each with its result. The ones that move numbers most:

- **140 staff test orders** ($634.41) removed, leaving 75,918.
- **318 pairs of accounts held by one person** (1,068 orders, $207,386 before refunds) merged, ignoring dots in an address on Gmail only. Merging the 101 dot-only pairs elsewhere as well would cut the customer count by 101 (0.17 percent) and leave repeat at 19.6 percent.

- **Channel tags written inconsistently** (Meta under four sources, two spellings of paid social, six campaigns in two spellings, 1,365 content partner orders tagged as referral) mapped: 50 combinations into 13 channels.
- **Ad spend in each account's billing currency** converted at the day's rate, giving Google $609,510 and Meta $637,779 in dollars. Meta reports on Pacific time, so platforms are compared by week.
- **GA4 gaps**: two days missing in May 2025 (about 30,000 events), 517 orders sent twice in January and February 2025, 10.5 to 12.1 percent of orders missing in each other month (May 17.2), and event times inside a session on a fixed schedule, so time to checkout cannot be measured.

A weekly health check flagged 9 of 53 GA4 weeks: the three weeks of repeated purchases, the outage week, and five weeks in May and June 2025 with healthy tracking and conversion of 2.695 to 2.882 percent against a normal 2.204, which do not look like the mid-year sale and are still open.

From what the platforms claim to what happened

Over three years Google and Meta reported 46,935 click conversions and Meta 5,608 view through purchases, against 38,236 orders the paid channels won: platform ROAS 5.66 against 4.70 internal. The walk below covers the 51 complete weeks of the GA4 year, 7 October 2024 to 28 September 2025.

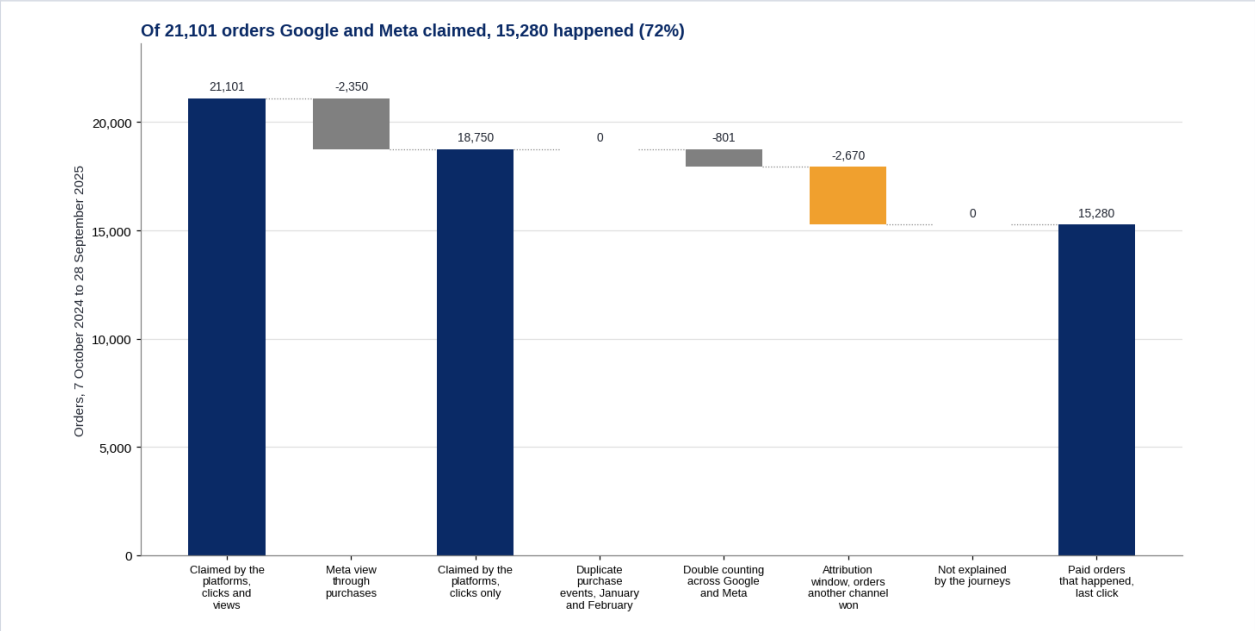


Figure 1. The reconciliation in orders over 51 weeks. Every step is sized from the data, and every claimed order fits inside what the click windows allow.

- **Meta view through purchases**: 2,350 orders ($350,038 at Meta's value per click purchase) from people who saw an ad without clicking.
- **Duplicate purchase events: zero.** Claims per order did not rise above their ordinary range in the weeks GA4 counted purchases twice (p = 0.683 and 0.506).
- **Double counting, 801 orders ($101,759), and the attribution window, 2,670 ($312,753).** Taking Google's click window as 30 days and Meta's as 7, each platform counts an order after one of its clicks inside that window, whoever won it. Google over-claimed by 23.2 percent of its own orders and Meta by 22.1, each about 45 percent of the room the GA4 journeys show. The over-claim is split between the two steps in proportion to that room: orders the other platform won, against orders an unpaid channel won.

- **What happened**: 15,280 orders, $2,438,753 before refunds. Less $74,271 of refunds the platforms never subtract, $2,364,481.82, equal to `channel_daily` for the same weeks to the cent.

GA4 saw 13,463 of the 15,280 orders (13,711 purchase events less 248 repeats): 0.884 of Google's and 0.876 of Meta's, a gap that is noise (z = 1.58, p = 0.115). GA4 is fair between channels, but its totals need scaling up by about 1.135.

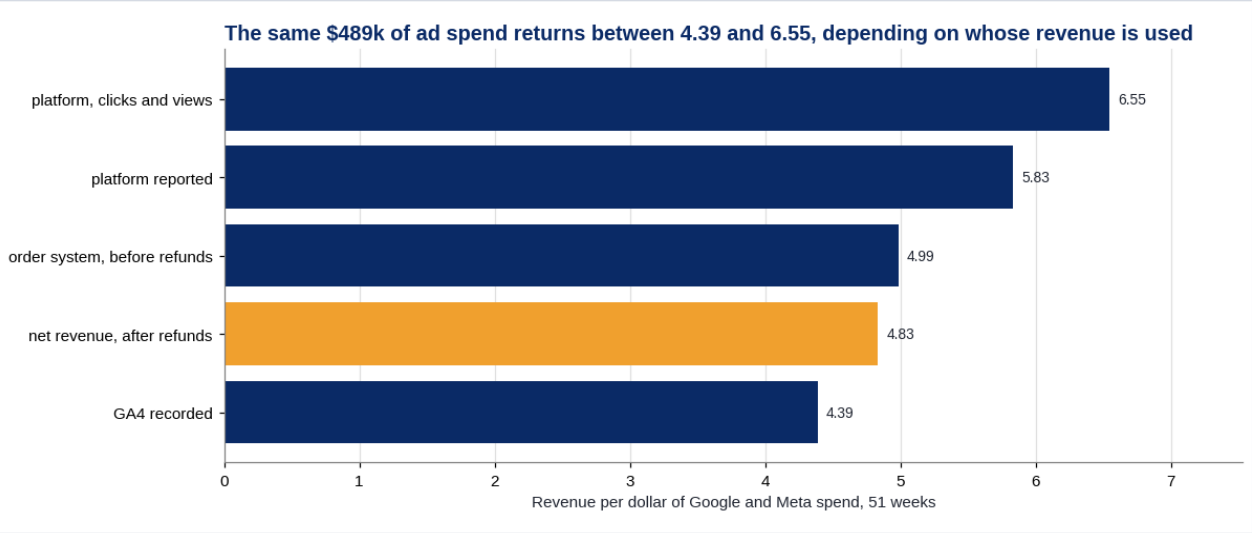


Figure 2. The same $489,213 of ad spend over the 51 weeks returns 4.39 to 6.55, depending on whose revenue is used.

Decision	Number to use	Why
Bids and creative inside Google or Meta	The platform's own conversions	What its bidding learns from, consistent inside the platform
Comparing channels and setting the budget	Internal ROAS, last click	One rule for every channel, no double counting, refunds off
Funnel and site behaviour	GA4, scaled by about 1.135 for totals	The only source of sessions, fair between channels
Revenue and profit reporting	Order system net revenue	The source of truth
Whether a channel creates sales	None of these	Needs a holdout test

No Meta figure should leave Ads Manager with view through purchases in it. The tracking plan sets out the fixes at source: purchases sent once, tags built from templates, real event times, and refunds passed back to both platforms.

2. How is each channel performing?

> **THE ANSWER**
> Under last click, brand search and retargeting look like the best paid channels and Meta Prospecting the weakest on every return measure. Meta Prospecting's visitors reach checkout and then do not buy.

Over three years paid channels brought $5,856,811 of net revenue and $3,715,559 of gross profit, email $1,250,083 and $779,808, affiliates $1,093,883 and $613,636, and organic search, direct and referral $3,707,098 and $2,312,057. Organic search is the largest single channel ($1,308,621 of gross profit).

Channel	Ad spend	New customers	Cost per new customer	Gross profit	Internal ROAS	Platform ROAS	Profit return on spend
Google Brand	$77,465	4,968	$15.59	$695,731	14.3	17.2	8.0
Google Non Brand	$331,980	9,514	$34.89	$1,100,228	5.3	6.4	2.3
Google Shopping	$200,064	5,577	$35.87	$531,063	4.2	5.0	1.7
Meta Prospecting	$512,242	9,750	$52.54	$868,119	2.6	3.3	0.7
Meta Retargeting	$125,537	3,150	$39.85	$443,647	5.5	7.1	2.5
All paid	$1,247,289	33,643	$37.07	$3,715,559	4.7	5.7	2.0

Profit return on spend is gross profit left after ad spend, per dollar of ad spend. All paid includes the two untagged channels. Net revenue by market, all channels: US 55.1 percent, UK 25.1, rest of the world 19.8.

- **Brand against non brand.** Google Brand returns 14.3 dollars of net revenue per dollar at $15.59 per new customer, the cheapest paid channel, and wins returning customers (6,833 orders from 4,968 new customers). Google Non Brand returns 5.3 but brings nearly twice the new customers and the largest gross profit of any paid channel. Section 4 shows how many brand search orders began elsewhere.
- **Meta Prospecting** has the largest budget, the lowest profit return on spend and the lowest paid AOV after refunds ($137.07). Its three campaigns cost $52.28 to $52.68 per order, so this is the channel, not one campaign. Like Google Shopping and Affiliate Content, it only ever wins first orders under last click.
- **Meta claims more than Google**: on tagged channels about 1.28 times internal ROAS against 1.20.

Where Meta Prospecting loses its orders. Meta visitors, about 45 percent of sessions, reach checkout and then do not buy: 15.8 percent of Meta sessions reaching checkout end in a purchase, against 37.5 to 38.0 for every other channel family (on the dashboard's Funnel page). Meta Prospecting finishes about 13 percent (14.8 on desktop, 11.4 on mobile, 13.0 on tablet), Meta Retargeting 32.6, 26.0 and 28.7. It does not look like the in-app browser (desktop is as far behind), a broken release (Meta sits at 13.9 to 18.0 percent in every month, the others at 35.4 to 42.8) or tracking (GA4 sees 86.7 to 88.2 percent of Meta's orders on each device, 87.5 to 88.7 for the others), so these look like real lost orders. Lifting the rate from about 13 to 20 percent would give about 1.5 times the orders and take cost per order from $52.54 to about $34. The tracking plan adds `add_shipping_info` and `add_payment_info` to find the step where they leave.

Its auction is getting dearer. Cost per click rose about 24 percent, from $0.631 in October to December 2022 to $0.784 in July to September 2025, while click-through rate barely moved (1.054 to 1.075 percent in every full quarter). Cost per order has not risen ($48.45 to $60.62 a quarter, no trend), because the share of clicks that became orders rose: 1.36, 1.49 and 1.62 percent in July to September of 2023, 2024 and 2025.

3. Which customers are valuable, and how should CRM win the second order?

THE ANSWER

Every costed channel earns back its acquisition cost on the first order. What separates channels is whether their customers come back, and Meta and coupon partners fall short there. CRM's job is the second order, timed to the term.

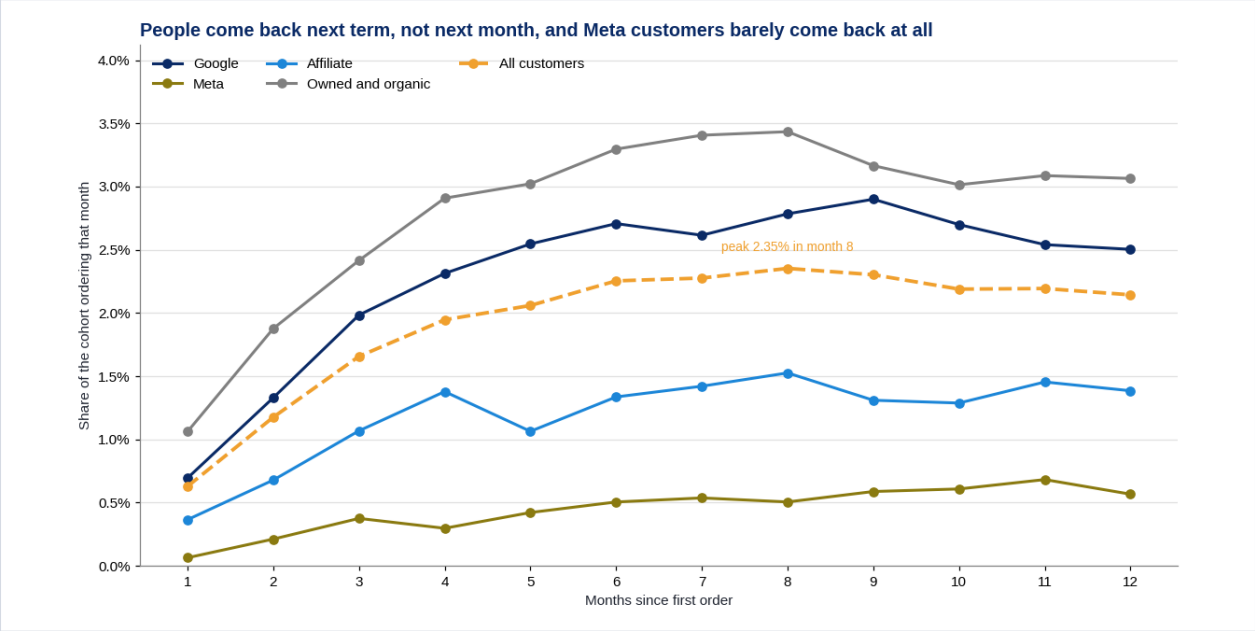


Figure 3. Share of customers ordering in each month after their first order, by the family of the channel that acquired them. Everyone who has had time to reach a month counts in it.

Only 0.63 percent of customers order again in the month after their first (347 of 55,195 who had time to). The share peaks at 2.35 percent in month 8: people come back for a later term, not the next month. 7,175 of the 36,569 customers with a full year behind them ordered again within 12 months, 19.6 percent; by acquisition channel it runs from 29.8 percent for referral to 2.5 for coupon partners (chi-square 2,406.2 on 12 degrees of freedom), with six channels above the average beyond noise and five below. Twelve month gross profit runs from $140.44 for referral customers to $81.95 for coupon partner customers; $21.77 of that gap is a smaller first order and $36.72 later orders.

Channel	12 month repeat	12 month value	Acquisition cost per new customer	LTV to CAC	Break even incrementality
Google Brand	26.5%	$131.65	$14.49	9.09	11.0%
Affiliate Coupon	2.5%	$92.99	$11.03	8.43	11.9%
Affiliate Content	26.5%	$137.96	$16.56	8.33	12.0%
Google Non Brand	26.6%	$134.66	$33.02	4.08	24.5%
Google Shopping	14.9%	$112.19	$36.41	3.08	32.5%
Meta Retargeting	6.9%	$97.26	$38.84	2.50	39.9%
Meta Prospecting	4.5%	$92.94	$53.08	1.75	57.1%
All channels	19.6%	$118.82	$20.46	5.81	

Cost and value describe the same people, acquired up to 30 September 2024, so cost here differs a little from section 2's table, which covers all three years. Paid channels are charged all their ad spend, the cautious direction for brand search and retargeting. Affiliate cost is the first order commission, added back to their 12 month value because gross profit already has it taken out, which is why Affiliate Coupon shows $92.99 here against $81.95 of gross profit. All channels is ad spend over every new customer; commission is left out of it for the same reason, so it is lower than blended CAC.

All seven costed channels pay back in month 0. The difference is what comes after: Meta Prospecting's customers have $88.01 of gross profit each in month 0 and $93.21 by calendar month 12; Google Non Brand's go from $102.44 to $136.01. So the budget question is incrementality, which the last column states as a break even share.

Sale code customers (9,447, $32.12 of first order discount) are worth $92.54 over twelve months against $126.01 for those who first bought outside a sale (p = 1.81e-195), almost all of it the first order: within the same acquisition channel their repeat gap is 0.64 points, too small to tell from noise (Cochran-Mantel-Haenszel p = 0.175). Black Friday code customers took the deepest discount ($49.00) and are worth the least ($76.61). People who bought on a sale day without the code are worth most of the three groups: $138.97 and 24.9 percent repeat, for reasons the data does not show.

Lifecycle stages and the CRM plan

Recency, frequency and lifetime gross profit are scored 1 to 5, with fixed frequency bands (77.6 percent of people have one order) and tied values always sharing a score. Ten RFM groups roll up into four stages: New 15,851, Active repeat 8,025, Cooling 10,991 and Lapsed 23,234. Only 969 people have bought four times or more. 37,183 people, 64.0 percent, can be emailed, and opt in runs only from 62.7 to 65.9 percent across the groups.

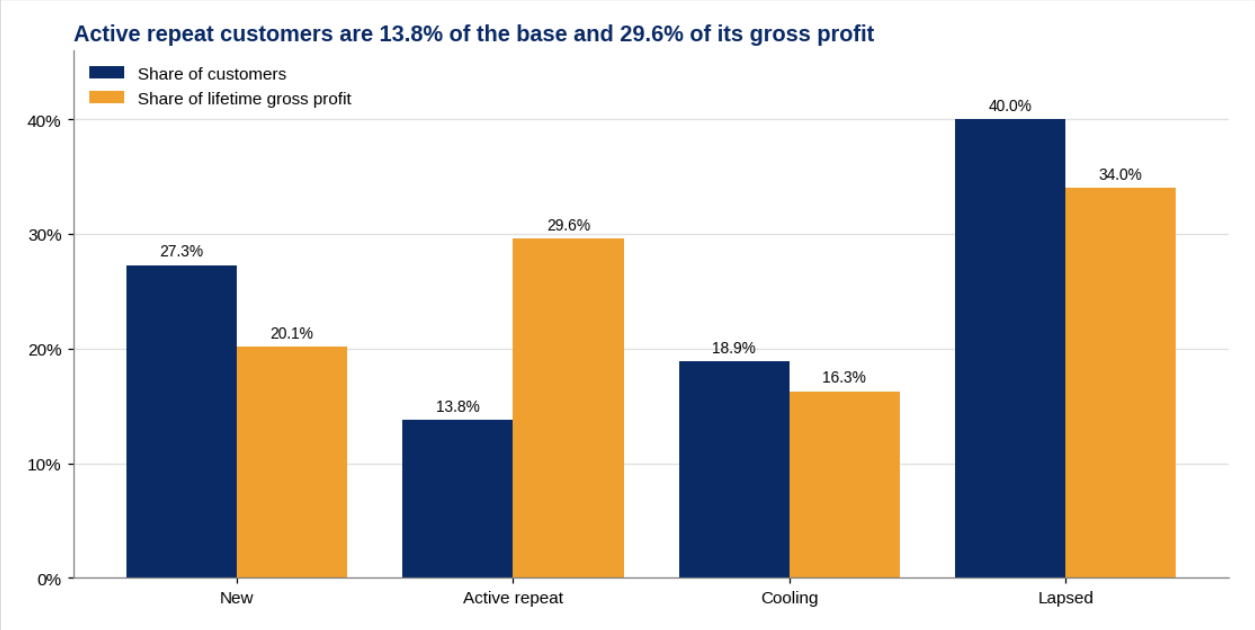


Figure 4. Each lifecycle stage's share of customers and of lifetime gross profit.

The CRM lifecycle plan runs one programme per stage, timed to the term, with the first order sale group deciding whether an email carries a code, two offer tests over Black Friday and the New Year sale before any code rule becomes permanent, and a 20 percent random holdout on every programme, judged on gross profit, never on email platform revenue. In FY2025, 21,532 people placed a first order and 13,736 opted in. A 20 percent holdout can detect a lift of about 2.4 points in twelve month repeat; each point on the roughly 10,990 who get the programme is about 110 more repeat customers, about $13,500 at $122.65 of later gross profit each.

4. Which channels and partners create sales?

THE ANSWER

No channel has a holdout or experiment, so incrementality cannot be measured directly. The data does show who opens journeys and who closes them, and where commission is paid on orders whose buying session had already started before the partner click. Brand search, retargeting and coupon partners mostly close.

A journey is every session the person had in the 30 days up to the order, with browsers linked to people through logins: 27,905 journeys, one for every order GA4 saw in FY2025. 46.2 percent are a single session. Last click gives the order to the last session, first click to the first, linear splits it equally, and position based gives 40 percent each to the first and last and 20 across the middle. Against last click, first click moves credit to the openers (Affiliate Content +190.9 percent, Meta Prospecting +81.2, Google Non Brand +54.2) and away from the closers (Meta Retargeting -87.7, Affiliate Coupon -78.9, Google Brand -73.8). Every rule hands out the same $4,442,205 of net revenue, and a bootstrap over the year's orders (400 resamples) finds 11 of 13 channels' order credit moving beyond noise under every rule.

In gross profit per dollar Meta Prospecting is last under last click (1.75) and Meta Retargeting last under position based (2.00). ROAS under another rule assumes orders GA4 missed split like the ones it saw; the planner shows last click and position based side by side.

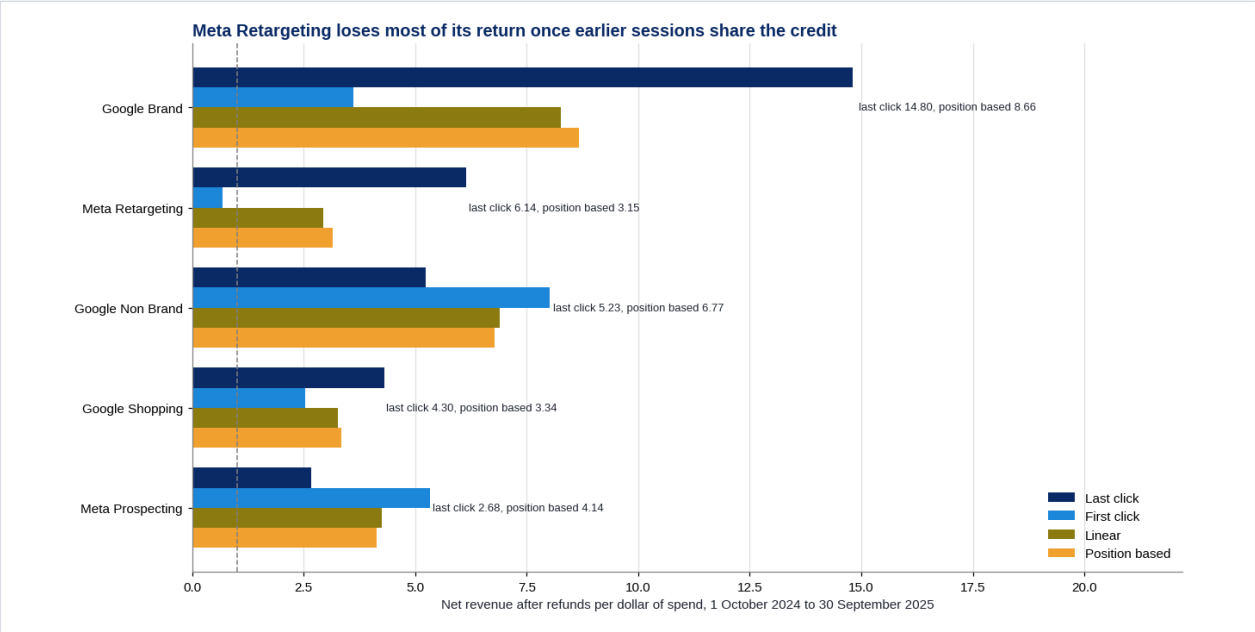


Figure 5. Net revenue per dollar of spend under each rule, for the five paid channels with campaigns, FY2025. The dashed line is one dollar back per dollar spent.

Brand search closed 2,499 orders, and 84.0 percent began on another channel (Google Non Brand 17.6 percent, organic search 17.3, Affiliate Content 16.8, email 16.0, Meta Prospecting 15.3). That does not prove brand search adds nothing, but most of the orders behind its 14.80 ROAS that GA4 saw were started elsewhere. The share of a channel's closed journeys that it also opened runs from 12.2 percent for Meta Retargeting to 78.3 for Meta Prospecting, close to each channel's share of single session journeys.

Coupon partners against content partners

Content partners behave like an acquisition channel: readers buy a median 123 minutes after the click, every order is a first order, and the order system credits every one to them. Coupon partners do not: 69.8 percent of clicks land within 10 minutes of the order (median 7.25 minutes), and only 31.3 percent of the orders they are paid on are credited to them.

$128,942.95 of coupon commission, 71.1 percent of it and 56.7 percent of all commission, sits on orders another channel won. On the 3,728 of those transactions GA4 saw, the buying session had started before the coupon click on 94.8 percent, against 10.8 percent on coupon credited orders and 11.8 on content. Those two set the floor; the gap to coupon credited orders is 84.0 points (z = 61.1). That points to buyers looking for a code part way through a visit in which they were already shopping. Commission also stands on 530 transactions on refunded orders, $7,903.14, refunded 4 to 44 days after the order.

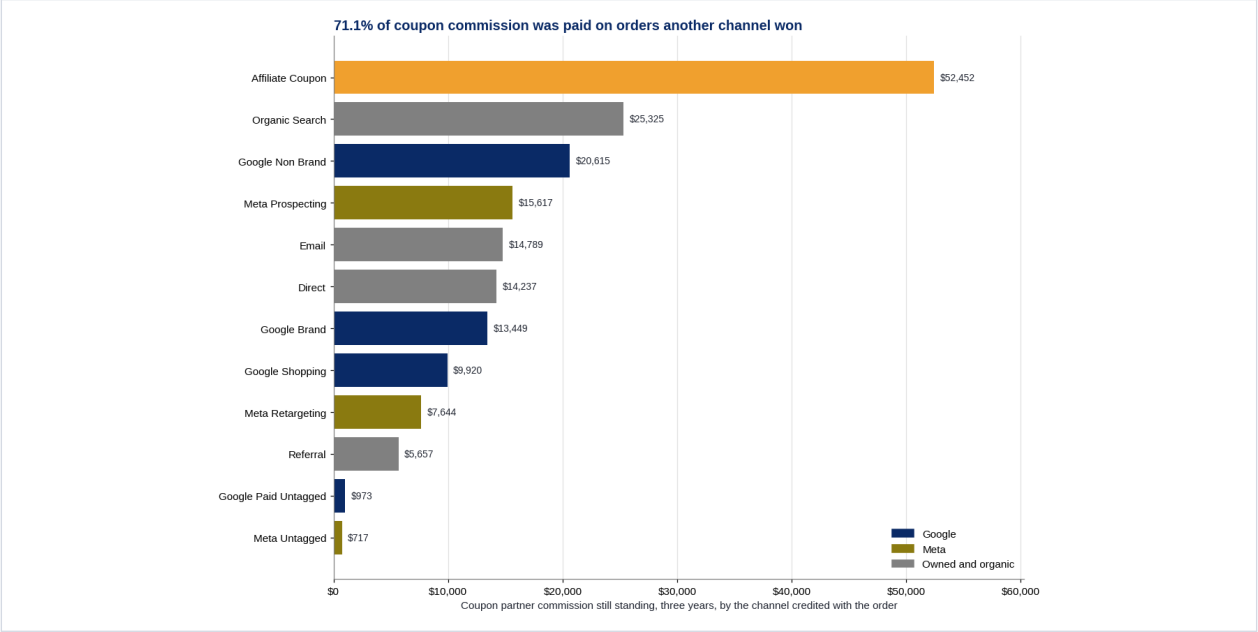


Figure 6. Coupon partner commission still standing over three years, by the channel the order system credits with the order.

Change	What it does	Saved, three years	Share of commission
Pay on credit	Coupon partners are paid only on orders the order system credits to them	$128,942.95	56.7%
Refund hold	Commission is held for 45 days after the order and dropped if the order is refunded in that time, which in this data catches every refunded order, $7,903.14	$7,903.14	3.5%
Both together		$132,606.99	58.3%

The two overlap: coupon commission on a refunded order that another channel won is already dropped by Pay on credit, so both together save $132,606.99, less than the two rows added.

Recommendation: adopt both. Commission would have fallen from $227,336.14 to $94,729.15 and gross profit risen 1.8 percent, about $44,202 a year. Content partners keep full commission on every order not refunded. If some coupon partners leave, the orders at stake are mainly the 31.3 percent credited to them, whose customers are the least valuable in the base ($81.95, 2.5 percent repeat).

5. How should the FY2026 budget be split?

> **THE ANSWER**
>
> Hold paid media at FY2025's level, move a fifth of Meta Retargeting to Google Non Brand, give Meta Prospecting nothing extra, and change affiliate commission terms. The biggest gain is the commission terms, not the media moves.

The FY2026 budget planner (Excel or Google Sheets) covers the five paid channels with campaigns, with FY2025 as the base. Returns scale in proportion to spend, which only holds near the budgets actually run, so a move of more than 25 percent is flagged. Meta Prospecting's cost per click rises 8 percent a year with click to order growth set to 0 (it measured 9.1 percent a year). Last click and position based sit side by side,

50 percent of credited new customers are taken as genuinely new (30 and 80 on a scenarios sheet), and every recommendation is measured against spending FY2025's budgets again.

Channel	FY2025	FY2026	Last click	Position based	12 month value, 50% new
Google Brand	$31,289	$31,289	$0	$0	$0
Google Non Brand	$127,144	$138,089	+$24,714	+$35,320	+$10,177
Google Shopping	$80,300	$80,300	$0	$0	$0
Meta Prospecting	$205,487	$205,487	$0	$0	$0
Meta Retargeting	$54,727	$43,782	-$31,558	-$10,932	-$2,412
Pay on credit and Refund hold			+$44,202	+$44,202	+$44,202
Total	**$498,948**	**$498,948**	**+$37,359**	**+$68,590**	**+$51,968**

Ad spend, then the change in gross profit after ad spend under each attribution rule, and in twelve month gross profit from genuinely new customers at 50 percent, also after ad spend, all against spending FY2025's budgets again. Rows are rounded separately, so they may not add exactly to the total.

- **Google Brand: hold, and test.** Highest return under last click, linear and position based (third under first click, 3.61 against Google Non Brand 8.01 and Meta Prospecting 5.33) and breaks even at 11.0 percent, but 84.0 percent of its orders began elsewhere.
- **Google Non Brand: receives what retargeting releases.** Gross profit per dollar rises under position based (3.26 to 4.23), it opened 58.4 percent of the journeys it closed, 26.6 percent of its customers return, and it breaks even at 24.5 percent. The move is 8.6 percent of its budget.
- **Google Shopping: hold.** Break even 32.5 percent, 14.9 percent repeat, some credit lost under position based (2.71 to 2.10).
- **Meta Prospecting: hold.** The checkout loss is unexplained, cost per click is rising, it needs 57.1 percent genuinely new and 4.5 percent of its customers come back; it opens journeys, so it is not cut.
- **Meta Retargeting: cut a fifth.** It opened 12.2 percent of the journeys it closed, gross profit per dollar halves under position based (3.88 to 2.00), 6.9 percent repeat and it needs 39.9 percent. Last click would keep it, so the cut is small.

At 30, 50 and 80 percent genuinely new, the plan's paid media earns -$51,418, +$246,935 and +$694,465 of twelve month gross profit after ad spend, with 2, 4 and 5 of the 5 channels paying for themselves; Meta Prospecting is the only one below zero at 50 percent. The table compares the plan with spending FY2025's budgets again in FY2026. Compared with FY2025 as it actually happened, the plan's gross profit after ad spend on the five channels is slightly lower before the commission saving, mostly because of Meta Prospecting's assumed cost per click rise, which happens whatever the split; with the saving it is $10,721 higher under last click and $28,151 higher under position based.

The first holdout test. Pause UK brand search for 8 weeks. That saves $1,209 of spend, against $11,182 of gross profit last click credits it with in those weeks. If UK gross profit, compared with the US, the rest of the world and the same weeks last year, falls by less than 10.8 percent of that credited figure, UK brand search costs more than the gross profit it protects. The UK share of brand spend is assumed equal to the UK's 25.1 percent of net revenue (the UK brand campaign was 25.0 percent of brand spend over three years), to be replaced with the campaign's FY2025 share before the test.

Limitations, assumptions and sources

- **Incrementality is not measured.** No channel has a holdout or experiment; break even shares and scenarios stand in, and the brand search holdout is the first measurement.
- **Diminishing returns could not be estimated**, so planner moves beyond 25 percent are flagged rather than trusted.
- **No sale is called incremental**: the weeks either side of a sale are different points in the academic calendar. Sales are judged on discount cost and customer value only.
- **Email** has no cost data, so it is left out of marketing cost, and there is no person level email data (sends, opens, clicks).
- **GA4 covers one year**, misses about 12 percent of orders and two days in May 2025, and stamps events inside a session on a fixed schedule. Journeys exist only for the 27,905 orders GA4 saw, and almost only logged in visitors come back, so no data driven attribution model is attempted.
- **The platforms report on different time zones**, so they are compared by week, never by day.
- **Affiliate partner ids do not match the source tags**, so affiliates are analysed by partner type only.
- **Recent refunds are not all in**, so the latest weeks' revenue and profit read slightly high. Twelve month measures use customers acquired up to 30 September 2024, so only the last weeks of the September 2024 customers' windows are touched.
- **Assumptions**: last click outside section 4 and the planner's position based columns; click windows of 30 days for Google and 7 for Meta; all paid spend charged to acquisition; the planner's 50 percent genuinely new, 8 percent cost per click rise and 25.1 percent UK brand share; the Gmail only duplicate rule (up to 101 people may be counted twice).

Figures	Source
Data problems	`01_load_and_checks.sql`, `02_data_audit.sql`, the data issues log
Totals, channels, funnel, Meta checkout	`03_clean_layer.sql`, `04_reporting_tables.sql`, the dashboard
Customer value, unit economics, stages	`05_customer_value.sql`, `01_customer_value.ipynb`
Reconciliation, attribution, affiliates	`06_reconciliation_attribution.sql`, `02_reconciliation_attribution.ipynb`
Budget, scenarios, holdout	The FY2026 budget planner
CRM, tracking, every column	The CRM lifecycle plan, the tracking plan, the data dictionary